

CHRISTMAS PARADOXES

TEXT: Luke 2:1-20 (NKJV) “*And it came to pass in those days that a decree went out from Caesar Augustus that all the world should be registered. ²This census first took place while Quirinius was governing Syria. ³So all went to be registered everyone to his own city. ⁴Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judea, to the city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed wife, who was with child. ⁶So it was, that while they were there, the days were completed for her to be delivered. ⁷And she brought forth her firstborn Son, and wrapped Him in swaddling cloths, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn. ⁸Now there were in the same country shepherds living out in the fields, keeping watch over their flock by night. ⁹And behold, an angel of the Lord stood before them, and the glory of the Lord shone around*

them, and they were greatly afraid. ¹⁰Then the angel said to them, “Do not be afraid, for behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy which will be to all people. ¹¹“For there is born to you this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord. ¹²“And this will be the sign to you: You will find a Babe wrapped in swaddling cloths, lying in a manger.” ¹³And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God and saying: ¹⁴ “Glory to God in the highest, And on earth peace, goodwill toward men!” ¹⁵So it was, when the angels had gone away from them into heaven, that the shepherds said to one another, “Let us now go to Bethlehem and see this thing that has come to pass, which the Lord has made known to us.” ¹⁶And they came with haste and found Mary and Joseph, and the Babe lying in a manger. ¹⁷Now when they had seen Him, they made widely known the saying which was told them concerning this Child. ¹⁸And all those who heard it marveled at those things which were told them by the

shepherds. ¹⁹*But Mary kept all these things and pondered them in her heart.* ²⁰*Then the shepherds returned, glorifying and praising God for all the things that they had heard and seen, as it was told them.”*

INTRO: Christians are people of faith. There is much about our belief system that cannot be proven by normal accepted practices of rationality. For instance:

- No one can explain how God spoke the world into existence...
- No one can explain how God created man from the dust of the ground...
- No one can explain how a God, without a body could become a man with a body...
- No one can explain how an all-powerful God could allow His sinless Son to die for the sins of humankind...
- No one can explain how a God man, dead for three days, could rise from the dead...

- No one can explain how Jesus could disregard the law of gravity at Bethany's launching pad to ascend to His father...

Many things about Christianity must be accepted by faith, therefore we are people of faith. The Scripture declares that **faith pleases God.** **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** Ephesians 2:8-9 (NKJV) “*For by grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, ⁹not of works, lest anyone should boast.*” Hebrews 11:6 (NKJV) “*But without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is, and that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him.*”

As people of faith, we must accept the fact that there are many paradoxes that populate the Bible, which is the book we accept as our rule of faith and practice.

A Paradox is defined as “*A statement that is seemingly contradictory or opposed to common sense and yet is, perhaps, true.*” (Webster)

Nowhere in Scripture is the contrast between heaven and earth more evident than in the Christmas story. Luke takes us from the power and fame of Caesar to the weakness and obscurity of a baby in a stable, and then declares the baby in a manger to be a superior to Caesar.

Look at how many times a paradox occurs in Dr. Luke’s rendition of the Christmas story:

PARADOX #1 - JESUS EXPERIENCED A HUMAN BIRTH SO THAT WE COULD EXPERIENCE A SPIRITUAL BIRTH

The thought of God becoming one of us is absolutely stunning to the human mind. If God became a human being He voluntarily accepted all the weaknesses, restrictions, and limitations experienced by mere mortals. How could a God

so powerful that He constructed the world, created human life, and spoke the planets into place, condescend to become one of His own creatures? Yet, Doctor Luke describes such an event with great detail, right down to the:

- Date and time... Tax time!
- City... Bethlehem!
- Place... A manger!
- Clothing... Swaddling clothes!

What does it mean for God to experience the birth and life of a human being? Man was created perfect and placed in a perfect world called the Garden of Eden. As perfect as his world was, mankind found a way to mess up his own world. Adam and Eve sinned, thus offending the holiness of God. As soon as Adam and Eve sinned, God unveiled a plan of reconciliation for a fallen race. Genesis 3:15 (NKJV) ***“And I will put enmity Between you and the woman, And between your seed and her Seed; He shall bruise your head, And you shall bruise His heel.”***

The only way sin could be atoned for was the sacrifice of a perfect human being. Wait a minute – a *perfect* human being? How could such a thing ever come to pass? From the time Adam and Eve sinned, decades and centuries came and went, yet not one human being could rise to the point of perfection to qualify as the sacrifice for sin. Romans 3:23 (NKJV) “***For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.***”

In the Old Testament, the only way a sacrifice could satisfy a Holy God who had been offended by sin, was for that sacrifice to be spotless, blameless, and perfect. Leviticus 1:1-3 (NKJV) “***Now the LORD called to Moses, and spoke to him from the tabernacle of meeting, saying, ²“Speak to the children of Israel, and say to them: ‘When any one of you brings an offering to the LORD, you shall bring your offering of the livestock—of the herd and of the flock. ³‘If his offering is a burnt sacrifice***

of the herd, let him offer a male without blemish; he shall offer it of his own free will at the door of the tabernacle of meeting before the LORD.”

To be the supreme sacrifice, this God man would need to take upon Himself the form of a human being and the only way to do such a thing was to be born into the world through the strength of human flesh.

Though Mary was a virgin, she brought Jesus into the world just like all other human beings are born. (Story of little boy’s who stole a statue of Mary from the Catholic Church and prayed “*God if you ever want to see your mother again...*”)

While describing the birth of Jesus, Matthew quotes Isaiah. Matthew 1:23 (NKJV) “***Behold, the virgin shall be with child, and bear a Son, and they shall call His name Immanuel,***” which is translated, “*God with us.*”

The bottom line is this... Jesus experienced a human birth so that we could receive a spiritual birth. Ephesians 2:1-6 (NKJV) ***“And you He made alive, who were dead in trespasses and sins, ²in which you once walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, the spirit who now works in the sons of disobedience, ³among whom also we all once conducted ourselves in the lusts of our flesh, fulfilling the desires of the flesh and of the mind, and were by nature children of wrath, just as the others. ⁴But God, who is rich in mercy, because of His great love with which He loved us, ⁵even when we were dead in trespasses, made us alive together with Christ (by grace you have been saved), ⁶and raised us up together, and made us sit together in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus,”***

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PARADOX #2 - JESUS ACCEPTED AN EARTHLY MOTHER SO THAT WE COULD RECEIVE A HEAVENLY FATHER

Luke 2:4-7 (NKJV) *“Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judea, to the city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed wife, who was with child. ⁶So it was, that while they were there, the days were completed for her to be delivered. ⁷And she brought forth her firstborn Son, and wrapped Him in swaddling cloths, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn.”*

The first appearance of Jesus was not in a stable in Bethlehem, He was an equal with God in the beginning. John 1:1-18 (NKJV) *“In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was”*

with God, and the Word was God. ² He was in the beginning with God. ³ All things were made through Him, and without Him nothing was made that was made. ⁴ In Him was life, and the life was the light of men. ⁵ And the light shines in the darkness, and the darkness did not comprehend it. ⁶ There was a man sent from God, whose name was John. ⁷ This man came for a witness, to bear witness of the Light, that all through him might believe. ⁸ He was not that Light, but was sent to bear witness of that Light. ⁹ That was the true Light which gives light to every man coming into the world. ¹⁰ He was in the world, and the world was made through Him, and the world did not know Him. ¹¹ He came to His own, and His own did not receive Him. ¹² But as many as received Him, to them He gave the right to become children of God, to those who believe in His name: ¹³ who were born, not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of man, but of God. ¹⁴ And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we beheld His glory, the

glory as of the only begotten of the Father, full of grace and truth. ¹⁵ John bore witness of Him and cried out, saying, “This was He of whom I said, ‘He who comes after me is preferred before me, for He was before me.’ ” ¹⁶ And of His fullness we have all received, and grace for grace. ¹⁷ For the law was given through Moses, but grace and truth came through Jesus Christ. ¹⁸ No one has seen God at any time. The only begotten Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, He has declared Him.”

Mary became the mother of Jesus so that we could have a Heavenly Father. Jesus became an earthly son so that we could be inducted into the family of God, thus being adopted by a Heavenly Father.

One of the most overlooked facts about Adam and Eve’s sin in the Garden of Eden is that the sin they committed broke the relationship between Jehovah God and the human race. Throughout the Old Testament the relationship

between God and man was strained, restricted, and limited at best.

In the best-case scenario, man was orphaned at Eden.

I realize there are many here today who do not, and never have had, a close relationship with their earthly father. This is a human tragedy, not unique to our day. The divine design of the human family is such that children and their parents share a very close relational bond. If you do not have this kind of relationship with your parents, it may be a little difficult to get your hands around the following thoughts.

Matthew 7:11 (NKJV) ***“If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!”***

The benefits of having a Heavenly Father are very similar to that of having an earthly father (Only better):

- The Heavenly Father protects His earthly children... Deuteronomy 33:27-28 (NKJV)
“The eternal God is your refuge, And underneath are the everlasting arms; He will thrust out the enemy from before you, And will say, ‘Destroy!’”²⁸***Then Israel shall dwell in safety, The fountain of Jacob alone, In a land of grain and new wine; His heavens shall also drop dew.”***
- The Heavenly Father provides for His earthly children... Philippians 4:19 (NKJV)
“My God shall supply all your need according to His riches in glory by Christ Jesus.”
- The Heavenly Father disciplines His earthly children... Revelation 3:19 (NKJV) ***“As many as I love, I rebuke and chasten. Therefore be zealous and repent.”***
Proverbs 3:11-12 (NKJV) ***“My son, do not despise the chastening of the LORD, Nor***

detest His correction; ¹²For whom the LORD loves He corrects, Just as a father the son in whom he delights.”

- The Heavenly Father models proper behavior before His earthly children... 1 Peter 1:15 (NKJV) “*But as he which hath called you is holy, so be ye holy in all manner of conversation.*”
- The Heavenly Father appoints His earthly children as His heirs... Romans 8:16-17 (NKJV) “*The Spirit Himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, ¹⁷and if children, then heirs—heirs of God and joint heirs with Christ, if indeed we suffer with Him, that we may also be glorified together.*”

One of the major differences between an earthly father and the Heavenly Father is that the earthly father dies and leaves his estate to his children, but the Heavenly Father lives to enjoy watching His children benefit from His treasures.

Jesus took upon himself an earthly mother so that we could have a Heavenly Father.

- On His mother's side, He was a baby born in a manger. On His Father's side, he was living in a world He created...
- On His mother's side, He was from Nazareth. On His Father's side, He was from the New Jerusalem...
- On His mother's side, he was thirty-three and one-half years old. On His Father's side, he was the Ancient of Days...
- On His mother's side, He was human. On His Father's side, He was divine...
- On His mother's side, He was fleshly. On His Father's side He was Heavenly...
- On His mother's side, he rode a donkey. On His Father's side, He rode upon the wings of the wind...
- On His mother's side, he walked in sandals. On His Father's side He walked through walls...

- On His mother's side, He was God Incarnate. On His Father's side, He was God Almighty...
- On His mother's side, He spoke affectionately to His parents. On His Father's side, He spoke the world into existence...
- On His mother's side, He endured the pain of suffering. On His Father's side, He was triumphant over pain and suffering...
- On His mother's side, He was subject to His parents. On His Father's side, He was given a name above every name...
- On His mother's side, He needed a lamp or a candle for light. On His Father's side, He will be the light of the New Jerusalem...
- On His mother's side, he became thirsty. On His Father's side, he gave the woman at the well water to drink that would quench her thirst for an eternal day...
- On His mother's side, He wept at the tomb of Lazarus; on His Father's side, He called him back to life again...

- On His mother's side, He could be in only one place at a time; on His Father's side, He is omnipresent...
- On His mother's side, He was as gentle as a lamb led to the slaughter; on His Father's side, He is the Lion of the Tribe of Judah...
- On His mother's side, He was buried in a borrowed tomb; on His Father's side He abolished death...
- On His mother's side, His body succumbed to death. On His Father's side, He rose from the dead...
- On His mother's side, He was born in Bethlehem. On His Father's side, He ascended from Bethany's launching pad...

Mary became Jesus earthly mother so that Jehovah could become our Heavenly Father.

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PARADOX #2 - JESUS ACCEPTED AN EARTHLY MOTHER SO THAT WE COULD RECEIVE A HEAVENLY FATHER

PARADOX#3 - JESUS BECAME SUBJECT TO HUMAN LIMITATIONS SO THAT WE COULD BE SET FREE FROM SIN'S RESTRICTIONS

Luke 2:4-7 (NKJV) *“Joseph also went up from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth, into Judea, to the city of David, which is called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, ⁵to be registered with Mary, his betrothed wife, who was with child. ⁶So it was, that while they were there, the days were completed for her to be delivered. ⁷And she brought forth her firstborn Son, and wrapped Him in swaddling cloths, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn. When Jesus put on the robe of sinful*

flesh, He willingly accepted the restrictions and limitations that such a thing carried with it.

Though Jesus was a God man, the man side of the scenario brought with it some limitations and restrictions. God becoming flesh meant that Jesus was limited by time and space.

Because Jesus was a human being He was limited by time and space. As such, Jesus was a passionate person who had varied experiences:

- He laughed...
- He cried...
- He loved...
- He slept...
- He became fatigued...
- He became disappointed...
- He developed relationships...
- He experienced the pain of rejection...
- He experienced the pain of a human body...
- He experienced the mortality of human flesh...

(Jesus in the Temple at 12 – We hear nothing from him until He was 30 – He was grounded!) The Scripture clearly states that He went back to Nazareth and submitted Himself to His parents and the result was, ***“He grew in stature and favor with both God and man!”***

Why does man suffer all these limitations and restrictions? Because of the curse of sin! In the Garden of Eden man was neither limited by time nor space! The entire garden was at their disposal, and when they sinned God drove them out of the Garden to prevent them from eating of the Tree of Life and living forever in their sinful condition. Genesis 2:22-24 (NKJV)
“Then the LORD God said, “Behold, the man has become like one of us, to know good and evil. And now, lest he put out his hand and take also of the tree of life, and eat, and live forever”²³***therefore the LORD God sent him out of the garden of Eden to till the ground from which he was taken. ²⁴So He drove out the man; and He placed cherubim at the east***

of the garden of Eden, and a flaming sword which turned every way, to guard the way to the tree of life.”

Jesus took upon himself the form of sinful flesh.
2 Corinthians 5:21 (NKJV) *“He made Him who knew no sin to be sin for us, that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.”*

What benefit is it for us, that Jesus would come to the earth and do such a thing?

- He became flesh so that we could become eternally saved...
- He suffered so that we could live a rejoicing life...
- He denied the enticement to sin so that we could deny it as well...
- He took stripes on His back so that we could be healed...
- He died on that horrible day so that we could live for an eternal day...
- He rose from the dead so that death would no longer have dominion over us...

- He ascended to OUR Heavenly Father so that He could make intercession for us...

How is all this possible? Jesus became subject to the limitations of the flesh so that we could be free from sin's restrictions!

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PARADOX#4 - JESUS WAS RECEIVED BY LOWLY SHEPHERDS SO THAT WE

COULD BE WELCOMED BY HEAVENLY ANGELS...

Luke 2:8-18 (NKJV) *“Now there were in the same country shepherds living out in the fields, keeping watch over their flock by night. ⁹And behold, an angel of the Lord stood before them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them, and they were greatly afraid. ¹⁰Then the angel said to them, “Do not be afraid, for behold, I bring you good tidings of great joy which will be to all people. ¹¹“For there is born to you this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord. ¹²“And this will be the sign to you: You will find a Babe wrapped in swaddling cloths, lying in a manger.” ¹³And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God and saying: ¹⁴ “Glory to God in the highest, And on earth peace, goodwill toward men!” ¹⁵So it was, when the angels had gone away from them into heaven, that the shepherds said to one another, “Let us now go to Bethlehem and see*

this thing that has come to pass, which the Lord has made known to us.”¹⁶ And they came with haste and found Mary and Joseph, and the Babe lying in a manger.¹⁷ Now when they had seen Him, they made widely known the saying which was told them concerning this Child.¹⁸ And all those who heard it marveled at those things which were told them by the shepherds.”

The Christmas story is replete with meaning but nowhere is the paradox of Christmas more pronounced than when the shepherds came to see the Christ child.

Shepherding was a trade that was interwoven into the culture of Old Testament times, but it was a trade that one performed if he could not find a way to excel in the socio-economic culture of the day. Shepherds were not the kind of persons one would expect to see at the event that would be the fulfillment of the Messianic promise. You would expect to see:

- Kings...
- Potentates...
- Influencers...
- Political leaders...
- Religious leaders...
- High-society people... (The upper crust is some crumbs held together by a little dough!)

Yet, here it is, right here in the Christmas story, shepherds were some of the first people to welcome this Godchild into the world! There are many things about this story that on the surface do not make a lot of sense; in fact, they are downright surprising! One of the shocking things about this story is who God placed on His invitation list to attend such an event.

Shepherds! Are you sure, shepherds? Yes shepherds! Why would God invite such a common group of people to the birth of His Son?

I believe the answer to such questions is multi-faceted;

- God wanted to demonstrate that He was coming to the earth for everyone... John 3:16 (NKJV) ***“For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life.”***
- God wanted to begin an object lesson that everyone could grasp... (Talk about the shepherding trade in the Old Testament and how we are compared to sheep.)
- God wanted to change His image in the minds of the people... (Talk about the differences between the way God dealt with people in the Old Testament and the way he chose to deal with them in the New Testament.)
- God wanted those who would accept Him to know that He would be the provider for, and the protector of, His people... Psalm 23:1 (NKJV) ***“The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want.”***

- God wanted to bring us to the understanding that, at the end of the day, just as a shepherd would bring his sheep into the safety of the sheepfold; he will gather us safely home as well... 1 Thessalonians 4:16-19 (NKJV)
“For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of an archangel, and with the trumpet of God. And the dead in Christ will rise first.
¹⁷Then we who are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds to meet the Lord in the air. And thus we shall always be with the Lord.
¹⁸Therefore comfort one another with these words.”

Jesus was welcomed by shepherds so that we might be welcomed by angels! Luke 15:7 (NKJV) ***“I say to you that likewise there will be more joy in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine just persons who need no repentance.***” Revelation 7:9-12 (NKJV) ***“After this I beheld, and, lo, a great***

multitude, which no man could number, of all nations, and kindreds, and people, and tongues, stood before the throne, and before the Lamb, clothed with white robes, and palms in their hands; ¹⁰And cried with a loud voice, saying, Salvation to our God which sitteth upon the throne, and unto the Lamb. ¹¹And all the angels stood round about the throne, and about the elders and the four beasts, and fell before the throne on their faces, and worshipped God, ¹²Saying, Amen: Blessing, and glory, and wisdom, and thanksgiving, and honour, and power, and might, be unto our God for ever and ever. Amen.” Revelation 20:1-3 (NKJV) “Then I saw an angel coming down from heaven, having the key to the bottomless pit and a great chain in his hand. ²He laid hold of the dragon, that serpent of old, who is the Devil and Satan, and bound him for a thousand years; ³and he cast him into the bottomless pit, and shut him up, and set a seal on him, so that he should deceive the nations no more till the thousand years were

finished. But after these things he must be released for a little while.”

It may appear to the innocent by-stander that the shepherds are out of place in this passage, but their presence was pre-planned and well thought out! Jesus was welcomed by shepherds so that we might be welcomed by angels!

CONCLUSION:

The end of the story is not recorded in the Gospel of Luke, it is found in the book of Revelation. In Revelation He who disrobed His Heavenly garment picks it back up again, when the greatest paradox in the history of the world occurs. Jesus, who was born in a manger, is honored with:

- Worship from heaven’s creatures... In the book of Revelation the angels, elders, and saints worship Him who sits on the throne.
- All the power of Heaven and earth...
Matthew 28:18 (KJV) “*All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.*”

- All of Heaven's riches... Heaven is a city that is adorned with streets of gold, walls of jasper, and gates of pearl – It ALL belongs to Him!.
- All the honor of the Heavenly beings and the inhabitants of earth... Philippians 2:8-11 (KJV) ***“Being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself, and became obedient unto death, even the death of the cross.
⁹Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him, and given him a name which is above every name: ¹⁰That at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven, and things in earth, and things under the earth; ¹¹And that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.”***
- All the blessings Heaven can afford... Heaven has unlimited resources - and we have become heir to it all.